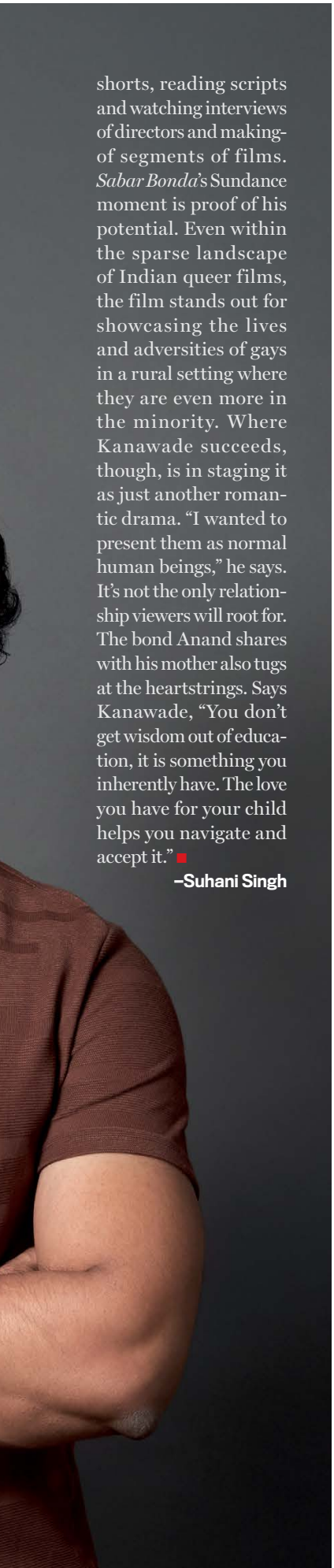
shorts, reading scripts and watching interviews of directors and making-of segments of films. *Sabar Bonda*'s Sundance moment is proof of his potential. Even within the sparse landscape of Indian queer films, the film stands out for showcasing the lives and adversities of gays in a rural setting where they are even more in the minority. Where Kanawade succeeds, though, is in staging it as just another romantic drama. "I wanted to present them as normal human beings," he says. It's not the only relationship viewers will root for. The bond Anand shares with his mother also tugs at the heartstrings. Says Kanawade, "You don't get wisdom out of education, it is something you inherently have. The love you have for your child helps you navigate and accept it." ■

–Suhani Singh



MANGESH PAWAR

OTT

HISTORY **BOY**

With his latest turn as Charles Sobhraj in Vikramaditya Motwane's *Black Warrant*, actor Sidhant Gupta may well have found his groove



While *Black Warrant*, the Netflix series about a rookie jailer in Tihar, may have put the spotlight on Shashi Kapoor's grandson Zahan Kapoor, who plays Sunil Gupta, the former jailer on whose book the series is based, equally arresting is Sidhant Gupta's portrayal of the 'Bikini Killer' Charles Sobhraj, who was a famous Tihar inmate in the 1980s. "He is a cool, sexy character and they have really gotten it right," says Gupta, who is an unabashed admirer of the show's co-creator Vikramaditya Motwane, a perfectionist whose "every frame speaks volumes". "His detailing is unmatched. I can spend a lifetime on his sets," he adds.

Gupta, who grew up in Jammu, savoured the sense of freedom that Delhi, where he was training for a commercial pilot's licence, gave him. He did a few modelling assignments, which eventually kindled an interest in acting, an arena more exciting than "sitting in a cockpit all my life". Gupta bagged a major role in the 2015 film *Badmashiyaan* and had a good run on television with *Tashan-E-Isqh* (2015-16), but he was itching to hone his craft. At a loose end after a cameo in *Bhoomi* (2017), which wasn't a commercial success, he decided to make a trip to London.

"That trip really changed it for me," says Gupta, referring to his meeting with acting coach Liana Norton at the Drama Centre London (now closed). In a one-on-one workshop with her, he "truly tasted the magic of acting". On a subsequent trip to LA, he met John Markland, a legendary acting coach who has trained the likes of Rami Malek. Gupta returned renewed, and landed some good roles, including that of Imaad Akbar in *Inside Edge Season 3* (2021).

In his latest phase, Gupta has veered towards playing larger-than-life historical personalities. His breakout role was that of theatre director Jay Khanna (inspired by Raj Kapoor) in Prime Video's *Jubilee* (2023)– another Motwane creation– which he has followed up with Nehru in *Freedom at Midnight* (2024), and now a convincing Sobhraj in the tightly paced jail drama.

"I really get obsessed with my characters. I think it's a good problem, at least for now," says Gupta

When Motwane called him for *Black Warrant*, Gupta leapt at the opportunity, although he knew little about Sobhraj; but his research into the serial killer left him transfixed: "I was like, this guy has a gift to fool the world." Gupta is an actor's actor, pursuing his craft with a single-minded passion. "I really get obsessed with my characters. I think it's a good problem, at least for now," he says. He's chuffed with his recent turn towards historical characters. "I like how these great people are finding me, and I'm finding them. I think I'm in a nice place right now," he signs off. ■

–Amit Dixit